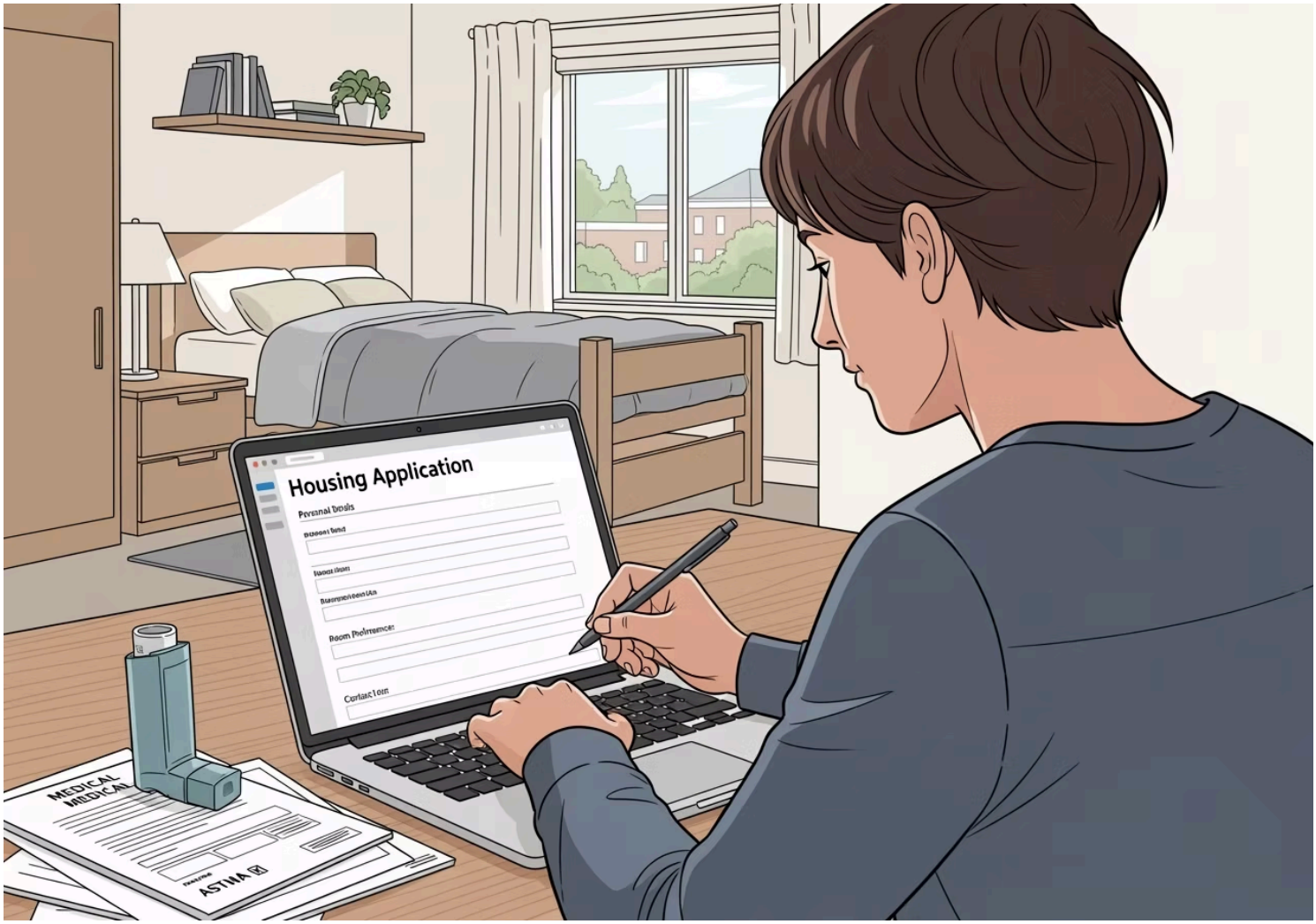
C.L.A.P.S. MD · Sep 4, 2025 · 2 min read

College-Bound with Asthma: Your Essential Preparation Guide

Making the Transition Smooth and Safe

Starting college is an exciting milestone, but for students with asthma, proper preparation is crucial for a successful academic experience. Here's your comprehensive guide to managing respiratory health on campus.



Creating Your Ideal Living Environment

Housing Requests That Matter Don't just check "asthma or allergies" on your housing form. Be specific about your needs:

- Request upper-floor rooms (avoid basements prone to mold)
- Specify "no pets" if you're allergic to animal dander
- Ask about carpet-free options when possible
- Inquire about roommate matching based on health needs

CLAPS MD Tip: Contact your school's disability services office early. You may need physician documentation to guarantee these accommodations.

Medical Preparation Checklist

Before You Leave Home:

- Schedule an appointment with your doctor, especially your pulmonologist for an updated asthma action plan
- Request extra medication supplies and backup prescriptions
- Ensure your inhaler technique is perfect

Research Campus Health Services:

- Are they available 24/7?
- Do they provide nebulizer treatments?
- What's their emergency protocol?
- Where's the nearest hospital?

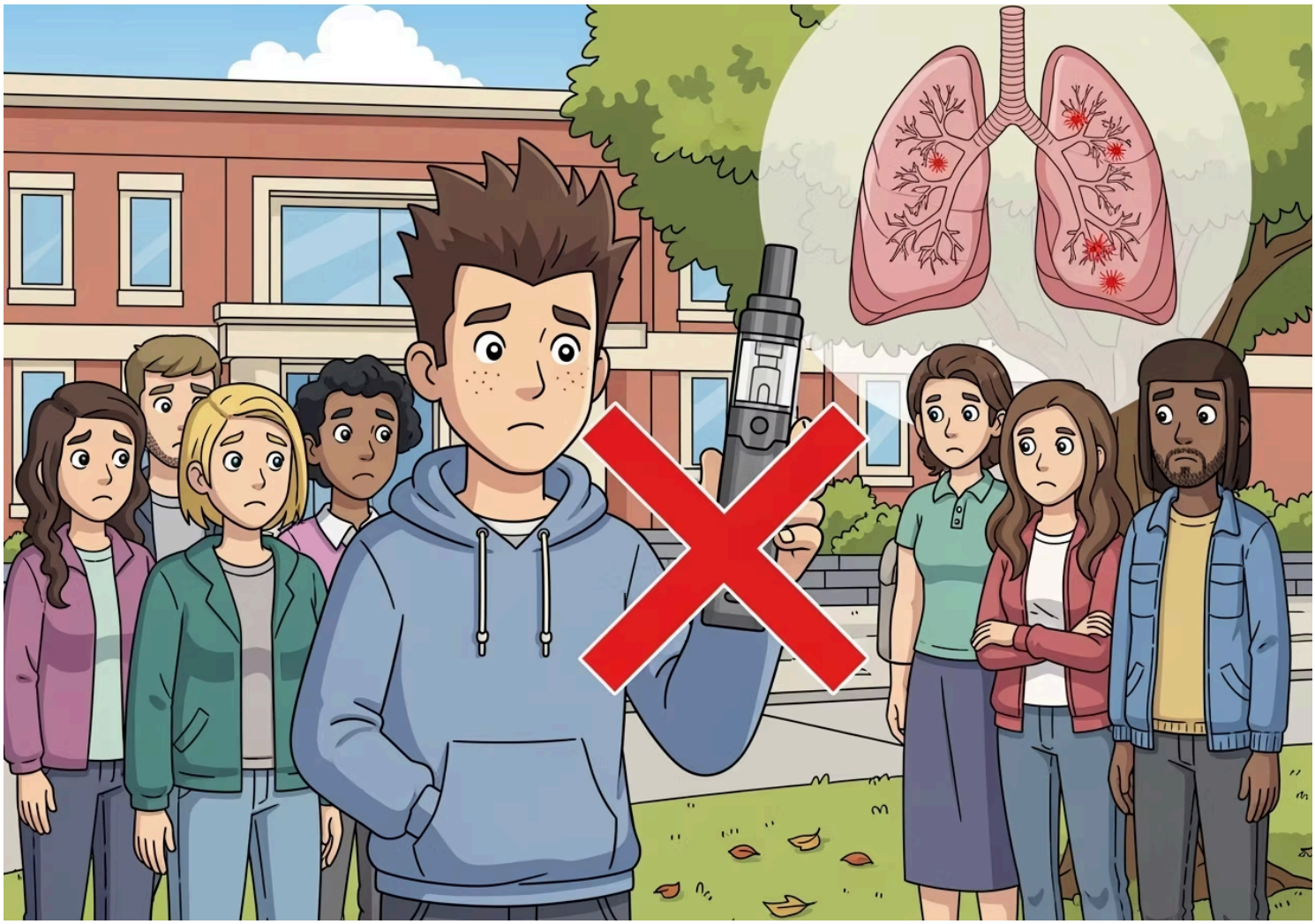
Dorm Room Setup for Success

Essential Items to Pack:

- Use mattress and pillow covers (extra-long dorm sizes)
- Plastic storage bins to minimize dust collectors
- Personal cleaning supplies and dust-catching cloths
- Dust mask for cleaning days
- Medications/inhalers with spacer devices

CLAPS MD Move-In Day Strategy: Encase your mattress and box spring immediately, before unpacking anything else onto the bed.

A Critical Health Warning: Vaping & Tobacco



Protect Your Respiratory Health Vaping and tobacco use are particularly dangerous for individuals with asthma and allergies. These substances can trigger severe respiratory episodes and worsen your condition long-term. If you've already started using these products, don't wait – we can help you develop a cessation plan tailored to your respiratory needs.

Secondhand Exposure Matters Too Living with roommates or spending time with friends who smoke or vape puts your health at risk. Secondhand smoke and vapor contain the same harmful chemicals that can trigger asthma attacks and allergic reactions. Don't hesitate to advocate for smoke-free living spaces and social environments – your health depends on it.

Environmental Awareness

Investigate Potential Triggers:

- Campus climate and mold risks
- Construction or renovation schedules
- Ventilation quality in your building
- Air conditioning policies

Monitoring and Communication

Track Your Health: If appropriate, remote patient monitoring devices may be available to keep track of your lung health. Also, review your asthma action plan if you notice any symptoms, and you can reach out to your parent as well as your doctor's office with questions or clarifications

Build Your Support Network: Prepare to educate your roommates, RAs, coaches, and close friends about:

- Your specific triggers and symptoms
- Location of emergency medications
- How they can assist during an episode
- When to seek help

Your Health, Your Success

Remember: managing your asthma and allergies proactively allows you to focus on what matters most – your education and college experience. Don't hesitate to advocate for your health needs.